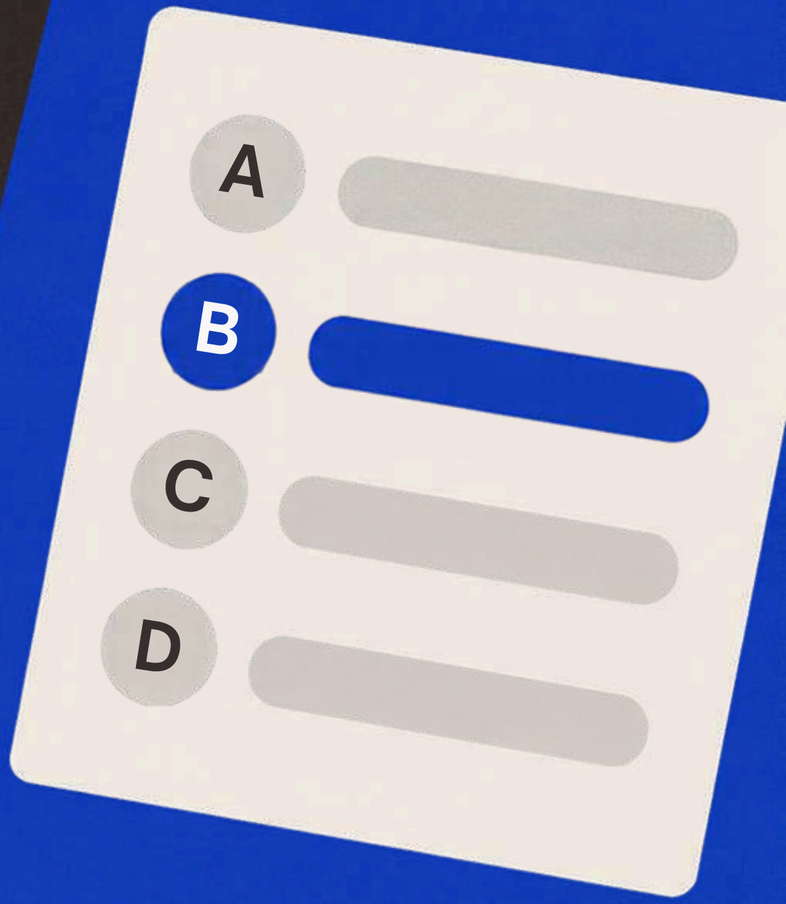
IELTS Reading: Mastering Multiple Choice Questions (MCQs)

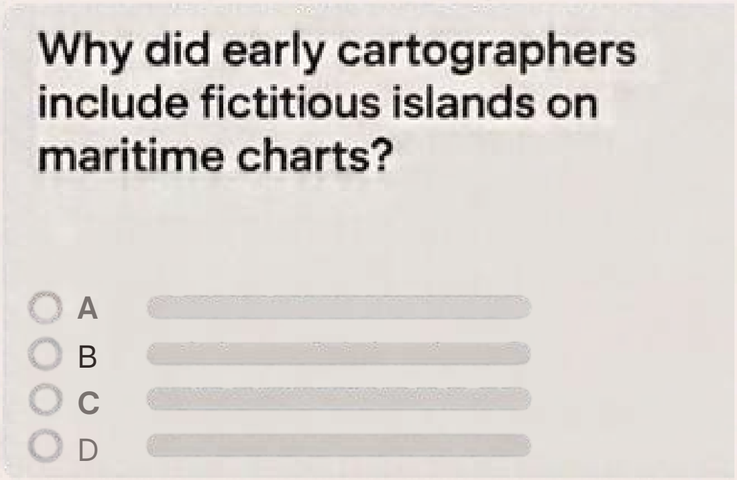
Structural Formats, Cognitive Mechanics, and Elimination Heuristics



Where They Appear & What They Actually Measure

Single-Answer Format
(Standard 4-Choice)

1 Question Stem + 4 Options (A, B, C, D). Worth 1 mark. Single radioButton input.



Multi-Answer Format
(Pick 2 of 5 or 3 of 7)

Which TWO of the following factors contributed to the collapse of the coastal fishery? Choose TWO letters, A-E.



Worth 1 independent mark per correct letter selected (2 marks total).

1 mark

Worth 1 independent mark per correct letter selected (2 marks total).

The 6-Step ‘Cover & Predict’ Execution Model

1

Read Question Stem ONLY.

Physically or mentally block Options A-D. Never read options first.

2

Underline Anchors.

Identify non-paraphrasable landmarks (dates, capital letters, technical terms, e.g., ‘Lake Baikal,’ ‘1984’).

3

Locate & Bracket Zone.

Find the anchor in the passage; bracket 2 sentences before and after.

4

Intensive Read & Predict.

Read the zone closely and formulate an independent answer in your own words.

5

Uncover & Match.

Scan Options A-D to find the option that matches your mental prediction.

6

Verify Elimination.

Confirm why the other three options fail on factual or grammatical grounds.

Live Demonstration: Predicting Before Looking

While early twentieth-century urban planners assumed that wider arterial roads would alleviate downtown gridlock, subsequent traffic telemetry demonstrated that additional lane capacity merely generated induced demand, prompting suburban commuters to abandon rail transit in favor of private vehicle travel.

According to the text, expanding urban road capacity resulted in...

More roads just caused more people to drive instead of using trains.

A. a rapid reduction in suburban train fares

B. an unexpected increase in private automobile usage

C. widespread praise from twentieth-century city planners

D. permanent elimination of downtown gridlock

Live Demonstration: Predicting Before Looking

While early twentieth-century urban planners assumed that wider arterial roads would alleviate downtown gridlock, subsequent traffic telemetry demonstrated that additional lane capacity merely generated induced demand, prompting suburban commuters to abandon rail transit in favor of private vehicle travel.

According to the text, expanding urban road capacity resulted in...

More roads just caused more people to drive instead of using trains.

A **a rapid reduction in suburban train fares**

train travel dropped, fares not mentioned.

B **an unexpected increase in private automobile usage**

paraphrases “generated induced demand... private vehicle travel'.

C **widespread praise from twentieth-century city planners**

their assumptions were disproved.

D **permanent elimination of downtown gridlock**

it failed to alleviate gridlock.

Classic Examiner Distractors (Part 1)

Trap 1 — The Keyword Bait

Dr. Chen's laboratory synthesized graphene derivatives to test water filtration membranes.

Distractor Option

Dr. Chen proved that graphene is the most cost-effective water filter.

Exact words can be copied into a wrong option while the subject or outcome changes.

Correct answers paraphrase; exact verbatim matches are overwhelmingly distractors.

Trap 2 — The Absolute Qualifier Trap

Preliminary trials indicate that regular aerobic exercise may lower the probability of cognitive decline.

Distractor Option

Cardiovascular workouts guarantee complete protection against brain disorders.

Watch for extreme qualifiers: ALL, ALWAYS, NEVER, ONLY, ENTIRELY, IMPOSSIBLE.

Classic Examiner Distractors (Part 2)

Trap 3 – The Causal Reversal (False Relationship)

Soil degradation accelerated as industrial fertilizer application increased.

Excessive industrial fertilizer usage was triggered by deteriorating soil conditions.

Check the directional arrow:
Did X cause Y, or did Y trigger X?

Trap 4 – Plausible in Reality, Unstated in Text

Smoking tobacco significantly elevates arterial blood pressure.

Medically true, but if the passage only discussed tobacco trade tariffs in Virginia, the answer is WRONG.

Treat the reading passage as a closed courtroom. No evidence in text = invalid option.

Treat the reading passage as a closed courtroom. No evidence in text = invalid option.

Advanced Heuristics for Difficult MCQs

1 The Differential Comparison Technique

When torn between two final options (e.g., B vs. D), do not re-read the whole sentence.

Underline the single operative difference (e.g., 'decreased mortality' vs. 'prolonged treatment duration') and search only for that concept.

2 Inspect the Stem's Reporting Verb

Distinguish what earlier scholars THEORIZED, what modern critics CLAIMED, and what the researcher PROVED.

If the stem asks 'What did Smith prove?', eliminate options describing Smith's preliminary hypotheses.

3 The 90-Second Cut-Loss Rule

If stuck between two options for over 90 seconds, select your highest-probability hunch, flag the item for review, and move forward immediately to protect chronological flow.

Test-Day Discipline: The 5 Non-Negotiables

1

NEVER

read Options A–D before the passage text. Avoid priming your brain with 3 engineered falseheads.

2

NEVER

stop reading at the first sentence match. Paragraphs may pivot with 'However' or ‘In contrast' two sentences later.

3

NEVER

leave multi-answer questions partially filled. On 'Choose TWO letters', picking only one throws away an available mark.

4

NEVER

rely on outside general knowledge. Anchor every selection strictly to sentence-level evidence.

5

NEVER

leave an MCQ blank. There is no negative marking in IELTS Reading; always register a final calculated guess.